MEDIA LAW & PROFESSIONAL ETHICS · CMM324

The Coolest Monkey Controversy

Media Ethics, Representation & Corporate Accountability

FRAMEWORK
The Potter Box model of moral reasoning

CASE
H&M, January 2018

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Introduction

In January 2018, fashion retailer H&M faced international backlash for featuring a young Black boy modeling a hoodie printed with the phrase “Coolest Monkey in the Jungle.” While H&M claimed no malicious intent, the ad was widely criticized for its racial insensitivity and disregard for the historical use of “monkey” as a racial slur. This paper uses the Potter Box model to analyze how H&M failed to uphold its ethical obligations, and how the case shaped industry standards on representation — especially when children are involved.

I. Defining the Ethical Issue

The core issue is H&M's decision to feature a Black child in a garment carrying a phrase historically used as a racial slur — reflecting a lack of cultural sensitivity and awareness of that history. The incident underscores how much context matters in advertising, and the harm caused when racial stereotypes are perpetuated, even unintentionally.

II. Identifying Values

- Corporate image and profitability — H&M;'s goal to market its products effectively
- Cultural sensitivity and social responsibility — the need to respect cultural context and avoid harmful stereotypes
- Freedom of expression — creative freedom in advertising
- Public accountability — responsibility to the public, especially marginalized communities

Prioritizing corporate image over cultural sensitivity is what led to the public outrage and reputational damage.

III. Applying Ethical Principles

Utilitarianism evaluates actions by their outcomes — the negative public reaction suggests this decision did not produce the greatest good. **Kantian ethics** emphasizes treating individuals as ends in themselves, not means — using a child to model a racially insensitive slogan treats him as a means to a marketing goal. **Virtue ethics** focuses on character and intention — the lack of cultural awareness reflects a deficiency in empathy and respect.

IV. Choosing Loyalties

H&M's primary loyalty appeared to sit with internal marketing objectives rather than its diverse customer base — a misalignment that led directly to a breach of public trust. The incident is a reminder that companies need to align their loyalties with both ethical standards and the communities they serve.

V. PR Responsibility & Children in Media

The controversy is magnified by the fact that the model is a child — a protected class in media law and ethics. While this case did not involve a privacy violation, it did involve a failure to safeguard the child's image from misrepresentation. PR professionals have a responsibility not just to manage a crisis after it happens, but to prevent it — often through more inclusive review processes before a campaign ever airs.

VI. Long-Term Implications

The H&M incident shows how brands can unintentionally reinforce harmful narratives through careless media production, and how quickly ethical missteps escalate in the age of social media. The case is now taught in media law and ethics classrooms as a cautionary tale: representation matters, and ethical PR requires more than good intentions.

Conclusion

The “Coolest Monkey in the Jungle” controversy is more than a PR blunder — it's a case study in ethical failure. Using the Potter Box model, this paper traces how a lack of cultural awareness, weak ethical reasoning, and misplaced loyalties combined to produce lasting brand damage. For the next generation of communicators, it's a clear reminder: ethics are not optional in media.